Catholic Morality: Chapters 4 & 5 cram sheet

Jesus as Moral Guide and Conscience Formation. Test: 50 questions (multiple choice, true/false, matching) plus one essay of about 7 to 8 sentences.

Conscience

- **Conscience**: a practical judgment of reason about the goodness or evil of an act; form it for life, then follow it. The secret core and sanctuary where you are alone with God.
- **NOT**: majority opinion, a feeling, the superego (Freud: leftover childhood rules), a gut instinct, Jiminy Cricket.
- **IS**: a law written on the heart by God; a summons to good; binding; the inner sanctuary; where divine law (love God and neighbor) is revealed.
- 3 aspects: relationship with God, awareness of God's call to love, practical judgment of the intellect. Works **before, during and after** you act.
- Not reliable guides: following the crowd, a gut feeling, obeying authority without thinking. **Sincerity is not enough.**
- **Collective conscience**: a community judging together for the **common good** (conditions that let everyone flourish).

Forming it: SEER

- 2 principles: always form and inform it; always obey your **certain** conscience. Sources: Scripture and Church teaching, prayer, trusted advice.
- **SEER**: Study the facts, Elect (with prayer), **Execute** (the true test), Review. A seer is a prophet.
- **Examination of conscience**: honest, prayerful assessment of how well you lived God's covenant of love; prepares you for Penance.
- **Virtue** = good habit; **vice** = bad habit. Repeated choices build one or the other.

When conscience gets it wrong

Invincible ignorance	Vincible ignorance
Cannot be overcome; NOT culpable (the act is still wrong)	Could be overcome; culpable

- Uncertain conscience: get more formation first. God's law, not opinion, is the final judge. Errors come from: ignorance of Christ, bad example, passions, false autonomy, rejecting the Church, no repentance, no love.

The eight Beatitudes

Blessed are...	for they...
1. the poor in spirit (depend on God)	theirs is the kingdom of heaven
2. they who mourn	will be comforted
3. the meek (not weak)	will inherit the land
4. they who hunger and thirst for righteousness	will be satisfied
5. the merciful (forgive)	will be shown mercy
6. the clean of heart (sincere intentions)	will see God
7. the peacemakers (restore relationships)	will be called children of God
8. they who are persecuted for righteousness	theirs is the kingdom of heaven

- **Beatitude** = supreme happiness. They open the **Sermon on the Mount** (Matthew 5 to 7). **Beatific Vision**: seeing God in heaven forever.

Sermon on the Mount

Old Law	Jesus' teaching
Do not kill	Do not stay angry; reconcile
No adultery	No lust in the heart
Bill of divorce	Marriage is lifelong
No false oaths	Yes means yes
Eye for an eye	Turn the other cheek
Hate your enemy	Love your enemies

- Jesus fulfills, not abolishes, the Old Law: **spirit over the letter**, a law of love. Intentions matter. Matthew 6: give, pray and fast humbly; don't put earthly treasures first.
- **Great Commandment**: love God with all your heart, soul, mind; love neighbor as yourself.

Jesus, the moral norm

- Moral norm because he is **God incarnate**, human and divine; perfect teacher (deeds back his words). **Kingdom of God**: peace, justice, love; now and not yet. **Repentance** (metanoia).
- **Eucharist**: Christ truly present; unites you with him and sends you to love others. **Corporal works of mercy**: feed, give drink, clothe, shelter, visit the sick, visit the imprisoned, bury the dead.

Virtues, gifts, fruits

- **Cardinal** (gained by effort): prudence, justice, fortitude (courage), temperance (self-control). **Theological** (infused by God): faith, hope, charity.
- Against faith: incredulity, **heresy**, **apostasy** (total rejection), **schism** (refuse the pope). Against hope: despair, presumption.
- **7 gifts**: wisdom, understanding, counsel, fortitude, knowledge, piety, fear of the Lord. **12 fruits**: charity, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, generosity, gentleness, faithfulness, modesty, self-control, chastity.
- **Sacramental character**: indelible mark from Baptism, Confirmation, Holy Orders; never repeated.

Peer pressure, fortitude, discipleship

- Peer pressure: neutral (fads), positive (pushes good), negative (pushes wrong). **Fortitude**: courage in doing good; built by self-denial, prayer, service; **offering up** builds it; **martyr** = witness.
- **Discipleship**: priest (offer daily life), prophet (proclaim Christ), king (self-mastery, justice). **Laity**: not ordained. **Evangelical counsels**: poverty, chastity, obedience.

Key: SEER = Study, Elect, Execute, Review.